A commentary on the essence of

# The Jewel Ornament of Liberation

of Dharma Lord Gampopa

by Khenchen Konchog Gyaltshen Rinpoche



# Ch. 1 Buddha-Nature

**Motivation and the Nature of Mind**

*Essence of the Jewel Ornament of Liberation, Ch. 1: Buddha-nature*

1. Please appreciate today's opportunity to reflect on the Buddha's wisdom on how to handle suffering.

2. Every sentient being desires to be free from suffering and to have all peace and happiness; but many don't know how to really handle the cause of suffering, and because of that they create more suffering.

3. So aspire, "Today I will reflect on the precious Dharma teachings to achieve complete enlightenment for the benefit of all sentient beings."

4. The fully awakened Buddha revealed the total reality-nature, achieved total peace and happiness, and taught the Dharma to all, so that everybody has a chance to reflect and gain wisdom.

5. In the world, we support each other as a community, so the peace or happiness that we receive comes from all sentient beings. Reflect on this and cultivate such an enlightened mind for every sentient being, based on loving-kindness and compassion.

6. Our mind is not matter; it is consciousness — it neither exists nor non-exists. If it did not exist, how could we feel, "I want peace and happiness"? If it were matter, we should see it or touch it, but we don't.

7. Like space, the mind has no limit. So we can develop bodhicitta to infinite sentient beings, as the Buddha did; bodhisattvas following that path did too, bringing great benefit for many centuries.

8. This practice is not a belief system; it is the way to wake up and reveal our innate nature — uncontrived luminosity, pure, precious — which is within us but obscured by adventitious confusion, the mental afflictions.

9. So we need to reveal this and see it directly. Then we can see these obscurations: their nature does not exist. We are not making these obscurations non-existent, but their nature itself does not exist.

**0.1 Because the perfect form of Buddha radiates**

*First reason showing that all sentient beings are always of the essence of enlightenment.*

1. Today we touch on the primary cause, the Buddha nature: every sentient being is pervaded by Buddha nature.

2. As the Uttaratantra of Maitreya says: "Because the perfect form of Buddha radiates, because there are no distinctions within suchness, and because all are in a family, all sentient beings are always of the essence of enlightenment."

3. Every sentient being has the seed of enlightenment. We call it a seed because we have not awakened yet. Actually, it itself is Buddha, Buddha-dharmakaya.

4. Since we have not perceived it and experienced it directly, we call it seed.

5. The seed of enlightenment is pervaded to every sentient being. So that is inseparable of the luminosity and emptiness. From the luminosity side it is called effulgence — pristine, clear, pure — but that very pristine, clear, pure itself is inseparable from emptiness. That is why it says "Because the perfect form of the Buddha radiates".

6. The Unsurpassed Tantra's first reason why sentient beings have Buddha nature is "Because the perfect form of the Buddha radiates."

7. Here, the form of the Buddha is Dharmakaya.

8. Then about Dharmakaya and to explain this first reason, Gampopa says: "All sentient beings are pervaded by the emptiness of Dharmakaya" means that the ultimate Buddhahood is Dharmakaya, Dharmakaya is all-pervading emptiness, and emptiness pervades all sentient beings.

9. And Gampopa closes this first reason by stating that therefore, all sentient beings are of the Buddha nature.

**0.1 Look at your mind, we can get a glimpse of its nature**

*Look inside your mind, directly glimpse it*

1. To achieve Buddhahood, we don't seek outside of us; we have to look inside our mind. Our mind has the nature of the Buddha.

2. Even now, though we are not fully awakened, we can get a glimpse of this — as we did in the short meditation, relaxing physically and mentally, making the mind calm and peaceful.

3. Then some mental affliction,
like aversion or attachment,
manifests in the mind.
Usually our attention is taken
by it; we go along with it and
go through a lot of confusion
and suffering.

4. But here, when any thought
manifests, just directly see it.
Where is it coming from —
outside or within?
Where is it located?
You don't find either.
It's just a thought.
What color and shape does
it have?

5. Then, finding that, you can see
it is just an illusory nature,
a manifestation of our habit.

6. We are so habituated — that is
called inveterate propensity —
that these thoughts of aversion,
attachment, "I," self,
manifest effortlessly.

7. But when you look at it
directly, with wisdom,
with special insight, you cannot
find that it exists anywhere.
The thought is there,
yet you cannot find its
location and we cannot find
the thought itself exist.
So it neither exists nor
non-exists.

8. So that finding,
when you meditate on this and
relax on this, you can see your
mind is so calm, so peaceful.
That is called effulgence,
the clear light.
At the same time,
the nature itself is emptiness.
So that is the Dharmakaya.

9. So that's the Buddha's wisdom,
that Dharmakaya within us;
it pervades all sentient beings,
no matter whether you realize
it or not.

10. Many people don't like to look
at it; they think it's boring,
there's nothing to see;
they are so attracted
by outer activities.
As meditators, we look at it and
meditate in that nature.

**0.2 Because there are no distinctions within suchness**

*Second reason showing that all sentient beings are always of the essence of enlightenment.*

1. The suchness of the Buddha
is identical to the suchness
of sentient beings.
None is better or worse, bigger
or smaller, higher or lower.
So, because of that,
all sentient beings are of the
Buddha-nature.

2. Look at your mind. All the different thoughts manifest. And when you use your special insight, with the support of calm abiding you cannot find that thought, because it does not exist as we thought — as something to grasp.

3. For example, sometimes we are so excited: "Why am I so excited? A very good friend of mine... So I'm so excited." Look at that excitement: without your friend, there's no excitement; without the mind, there's no excitement.That very excitement itself is of very illusory nature — just a display of causes and conditions, but in its own nature, itself does not exist. That is what is called suchness.

4. Between the suchness of the Buddha and the suchness of sentient beings, there is not a single difference. When you see this directly, all your grasping and fixations dissipate, and then that makes your mind calm and peaceful: there is nothing to attach to and hate.

5. When you could practice this, slowly your mind adjusts to this practice and becomes clearer and clearer. From that clarity, the qualities will manifest from your mind: the understanding of causality, of bodhicitta, how you can develop loving-kindness and compassion.

6. These qualities come out because our adventitious obscurations, the defilements, subside; slowly, slowly they go away and have no place to abide within us... So that mind neither exists nor non-exists; the effulgence of the clarity of the mind becomes clearer and clearer. So that itself is the Buddha's mind, and we have that within us.

7. The Buddha's mind is no better than our mind — neither higher nor lower, neither better nor worse. For example, the emptiness of my right hand is not worse than the emptiness of my left hand, no difference in their emptiness. The emptiness of my happiness and the emptiness of my suffering: no difference.

8. When we realize that, we don't
attach to our happiness;
we don't hate our suffering.
When we comprehend that,
that very nature itself is joy,
because the Buddha nature
itself is peace and joy.
That is how we achieve
undefiled, unafflicted peace.

9. We don't have to look for it;
it is within us, but we need
the skill to reveal it:
study and practice have
to go side by side.
Without practice, study is
just knowledge; without study,
you have no tool to practice.

**0.3 Because all are in a family**

*Third reason showing that all sentient beings are always of the essence of enlightenment*

1. The Unsurpassed Tantra's
third reason is "Because
all are in a family."
Here family means we have
the opportunity, a way to
actualize this suchness, the
ability to see the Dharmakaya
that we have within us.
So all sentient beings are
within the family.

2. Five families are mentioned:
disconnected, indefinite,
hearer, solitary realizer,
and Mahayana.
Disconnected means that,
for the time being,
some individuals' adventitious
obscurations are so thick that
they have no feeling of concern
about anything, right or wrong.

3. It is like the moon in such
a dark cloud: for the time
being you cannot see the moon,
but it doesn't mean it is
always that way. Slowly,
through causes and conditions,
the cloud will disappear.
But the moon is there,
and that moon can appear.

4. Likewise, life after life,
slowly the disconnected
connect to the teaching of
wisdom and can fully awaken.
That is why the Buddhas
and great bodhisattvas are
reborn again and again,
as long as samsara exists
they never give up.
Every being has the opportunity;
it may take time, but eventually
anything is possible.

5. Cultivate bodhicitta that way,
sometimes it takes time.
But slowly, slowly we can
make it.

6. Even in our own practice,
sometimes we feel,
"There's no progress.
I have chanted so many mantras,
I have meditated so many years,
but still my very thick,
obscured mind — it's difficult."
But if we continue without
losing courage, interest,
or devotion to the Dharma,
to the Buddha, definitely we can
progress step-by-step.

7. Especially we have to develop
bodhicitta. It's not easy
even to help one person.
You repeat again and again,
and they don't get it.
But from your side, never
give up; always go forward:
meditate, helping others,
helping yourself.

8. That's called family.
Even though they are divided
into five families, at the
end all are in one family,
Buddhahood: in Sanskrit,
Ekayana, the one vehicle,
the mahayana family

9. With these teachings on
Buddha nature we should
inspire ourselves:
"I have the Buddha nature.
If I study and practice Dharma,
I can make it.
I'm so fortunate that now I
have met the Dharma teachings
in my life."

10. Then we also respect
all sentient beings:
"Everyone is like me;
they want peace and happiness
and to be free from suffering.
Everyone has the
Buddha-nature and the
potential to become Buddha."
Then there is a reason to
cultivate loving-kindness,
compassion, and bodhicitta
toward all of them,
and through this practice we get
all the opportunity to purify
our own defilements.

**V. The mahayana family**

*Classification, definition, synonyms, superior to other families, causal characteristics, and marks*

1. In the Mahayana family there
are six topics: classification,
definition, synonyms, reason it
is superior to other families,
causal characteristics,
and marks.

2. Classification means division.
There are two divisions
of the Mahayana family,
the naturally abiding family and
the perfectly workable family.
These two are very important
for us to understand.

3. Naturally abiding family means every sentient being has the Buddha nature; it is the natural mode of abiding, the basic disposition. Even though they are not prepared yet, in their mind the Buddha nature is naturally abiding, the nature of effulgence is there.

4. Perfectly workable family means those who are interested in the Dharma, study and practice, especially bodhicitta: practicing loving-kindness and compassion to all sentient beings, and cultivating repeatedly, "I want to attain Buddhahood for the benefit of all sentient beings." Life after life, we have been studying and practicing this.

5. The synonyms of family: it is called potential, because whoever has the Buddha nature has the potential to become Buddha; it is called seed; and it is called sphere-element. Sphere means all-pervasive: the potential is there; it is infinite.

6. The shravakas and pratyekabuddhas purify only the obscuration of the afflictions: they cut through self-grasping, realize selflessness, and attain the arhat state. The bodhisattvas become Buddha because the two obscurations — the obscuration of the mental afflictions and the subtle knowledge obscuration — are both thoroughly purified; then the Mahayana family is fully awakened, and that is why it is called superior. But arhats also can attain Buddhahood.

7. Those of the disconnected family take a long time to become Buddha. In the indefinite family, those who connect to the Mahayana, it won't take too long, but those who connect to the shravakas and pratyekabuddhas take a longer time. Shravakas and pratyekabuddhas take a long time, but much sooner than the disconnected family. Those who belong to the Mahayana, it won't take too long to become Buddha.

### V.F Examples and closing remarks on Buddha-nature

*Sentient beings can become Buddhas.*

1. By the above three reasons —
   the Dharmakaya pervades every
   sentient being, the suchness
   of the Buddha and of sentient
   beings is no different,
   and everyone has a family — know
   that all have the Buddha nature.

2. Furthermore,
   consider these examples:
   silver abiding in its ore,
   oil abiding in a mustard seed,
   and butter abiding in milk.
   From silver ore we can produce
   silver; from the seed,
   oil; from milk, butter.
   Likewise, sentient beings can
   become Buddha.

3. For example, the gold within
   the raw material and the gold
   already refined from it:
   there's no difference,
   the same nature.

4. Like the butter in the milk and
   the butter which is produced:
   there's no difference.
   The only difference is that the
   butter in the milk you cannot
   see as butter or use as butter;
   the butter which is produced,
   we can see and use as butter.

5. So we sentient beings in
   samsara, even though we have
   every potential of the Buddha,
   cannot say, "I'm a Buddha,"
   and cannot do as the Buddha
   does, helping sentient beings,
   because the enlightened
   qualities are obscured by
   temporary obscurations.

6. The Buddha nature,
   the primary cause,
   pervades all sentient beings.
   Just relax, reflect on this,
   and meditate: even I can do it
   now; it's not far away.

7. Sometimes we feel the Buddha is
   somewhere out there, and "I am
   so insignificant; I am nothing."
   But if you touch these teachings
   and reflect on them, you can
   see: "I have the Buddha nature.
   I can see it.
   I can experience it."

8. If we don't know how to
   practice these teachings,
   it still feels so far.
   In that case, we keep analyzing
   more and more — no end, because
   there's no end of thinking.
   That's why we have to know
   how to sit, reflect on this,
   meditate, and digest the
   teachings; then you can say,
   "Oh yes, I can make it."